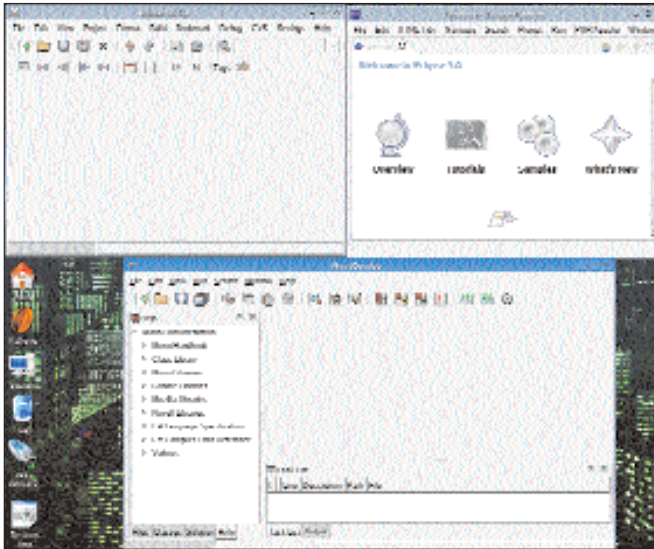




There is a plethora of development tools bundled with OpenLx, such as Mono development suite, Eclipse suite and much more...

RedHat WS, Fedora 4 and OpenLx are pretty much the same and once installed, default to a customised KDE desktop. Apart from a few icons, there is hardly anything that distinguishes WS from Fedora. However, the developer of OpenLx has done some amount of work to distinguish itself from the Fedora core and also convey its India roots.

In Mandrake, once the installation is done, it offers a choice as the default environment—KDE, Gnome or other environments. It also offers to download the latest patches and packages before proceeding to the desktop. Finally, you are asked to take part in a survey and then to agree to the user license before it takes you to a blue KDE desktop.

SuSe also follows a pattern similar to Mandrake, before defaulting to a pleasant green KDE desktop.

On the hardware detection front, almost all distros were able to detect every single component of our testbeds. There were some minor issues though; Ubuntu failed to load once on the i875 chipset machine, but after a reinstall worked perfectly.

During installation, SuSe was able to take 1280 x 1024 resolution on the 17-inch TFT monitor however, once the installation was complete, it defaulted to 1024 x 768 and also detected it as a CRT monitor. Some tweaking with Yast2 solved the problem. Fedora core 4, RedHat, OpenLx and Mandrake were bang-on, detecting everything in the first go.

As compared to last year's Linux comparison, we faced relatively less hardware incompatibility issues this time. This goes to say that the community has done a great amount of work in sorting out driver issues. To give you a perspective: when we connected our 400 GB hard drive to Windows without SP1, it only detected about 120 GB or so, but the same drive was detected perfectly in all these distros. Unbelievable? Better, believe it!

Usability

A lot depends on the environment you prefer, when talking about usability. KDE offers the intuitiveness of Windows, but is a system hog and requires real processing power to run at its best. Also, since most Linux distros are based around KDE, the number of applications that are developed and bundled along with the

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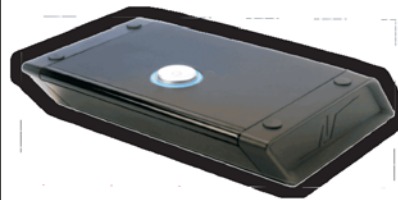
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